SebTreb rules for ArchiMate modelling - edit

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Introduction

SebTreb rules are named after Sebastian Trebaczkiewicz who led the EA team from 2020 to 2024. Seb was a meticulous architect when it came to drawing architectural views and set the quality benchmark for our architects. Furthermore, the annual Christmas competition adopted SebTreb rules as the marking scheme for challenges.

The purpose of this page is to outline the specific SebTreb rules.

Key words

The key words "MUST", "MUST NOT", "REQUIRED", "SHALL", "SHALL NOT", "SHOULD", "SHOULD NOT", "RECOMMENDED", "MAY", and "OPTIONAL" in this document are to be interpreted as described in RFC 2119.

Objectives

Architectural views are the main deliverables for an architect when modelling a system. An architectural view may be technically sound - meeting all business requirements, constraints, NFRs etc. - however, if the view is not understood by the target stakeholders, then it will have limited value. A key aspect of view creation is the style - including layout, symbology, simplicity and nomenclature. The overall goal is to ensure architectural views are easy to understand, clear and are appealing to look at. Think of them as a piece of art.

The objectives of defining some basic style guidelines for STS architects to adhere to can ultimately be summarised as:

1. Improved **readability** for target stakeholders - meaning those stakeholders are far more likely to consume the deliverables, and understand them.

2. Better **consistency** when creating architectural views - across STS, across a client's deliverables or within a specific project / engagement.
3. Increased **productivity** during the modelling of a system, as less time needs to be used for considering style. The easier something is to understand, the less time wasted on inflated explanations.

Caveats

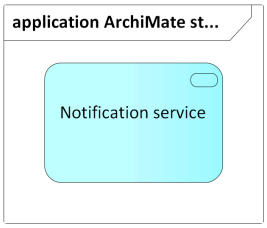
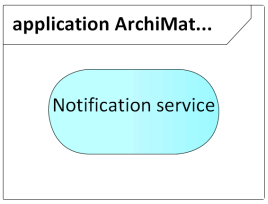
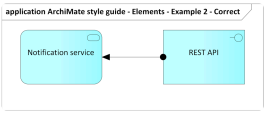
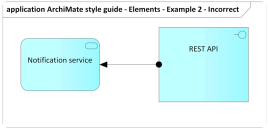
The guidelines defined on this page should be treated as that - guidelines. Where possible, the guidelines must be followed as closely as possible. However, there are certain scenarios where not adhering to a specific rule is not only acceptable, but also potentially preferable. Ultimately, if following a rule will result in the output being less readable, then the rule can be challenged. Also, it is impossible to be able to define rules that will cover every permutation, so you should always be using your judgement when considering the guidelines and always keep the objectives above in mind.

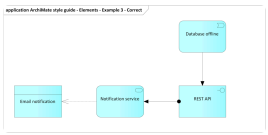
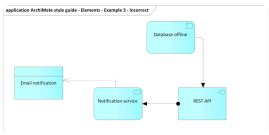
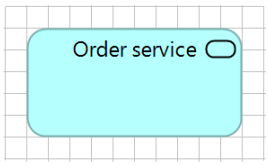
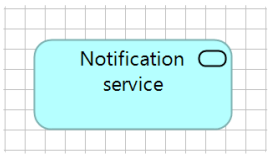
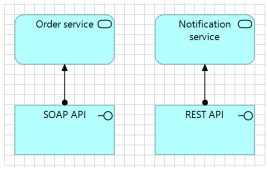
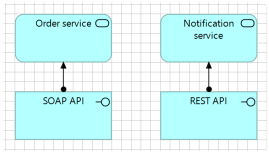
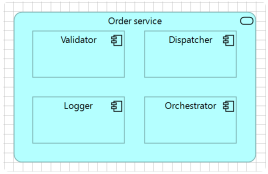
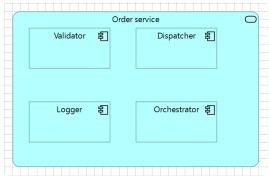
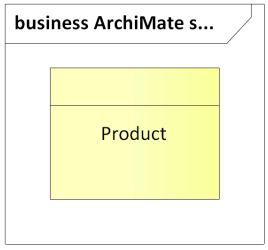
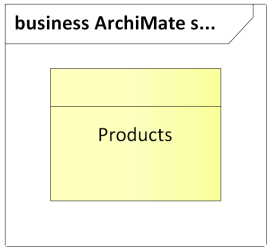
Where caveats are likely to be accepted, some examples are listed alongside the specific style rule. If a particular style rule has N/A defined for example caveats, it means the rule MUST be adhered to.

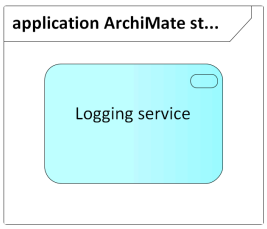
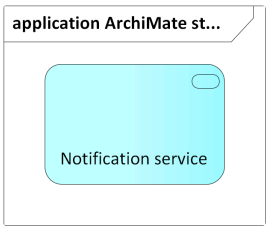
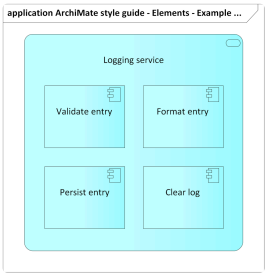
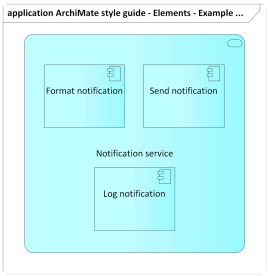
Additionally - as always, if a client has their own style guidelines they wish you to follow, those should take precedence.

ArchiMate style guidelines

Elements

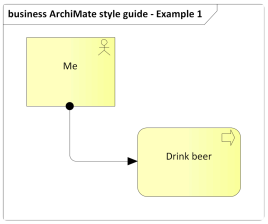
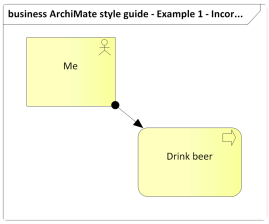
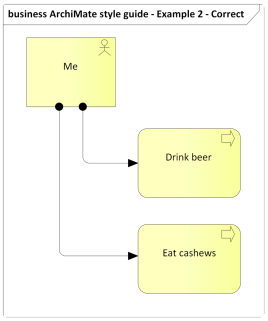
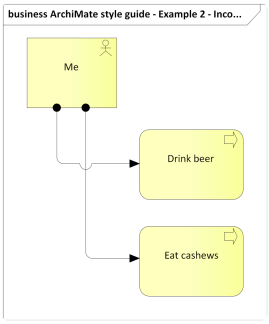
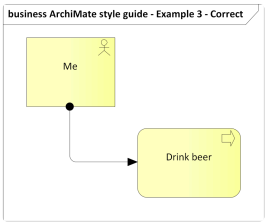
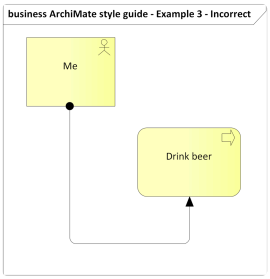
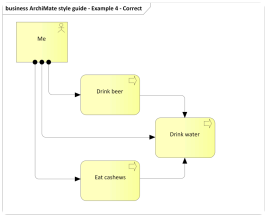
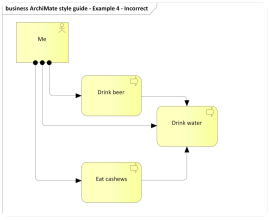
Rule	Description	Example (correct)	Example (incorrect)	Caveats
elm-001	Elements MUST be represented using the rectangle notation.			N/A
elm-002	Elements SHOULD be the same size.			• The element is used to encapsulate other elements.

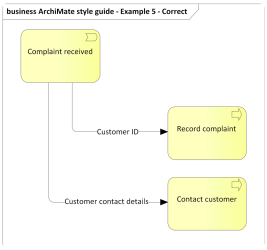
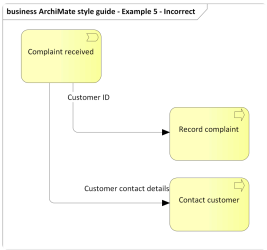
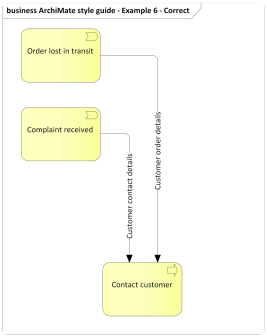
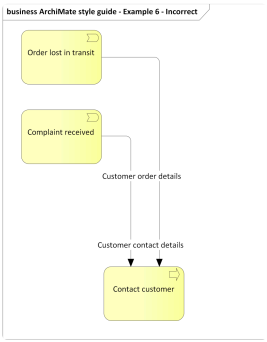
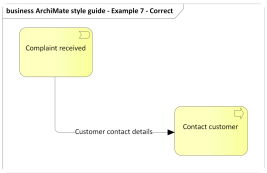
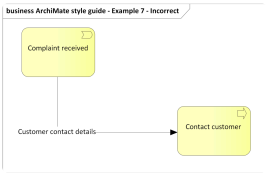
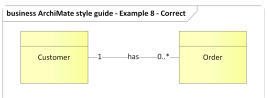
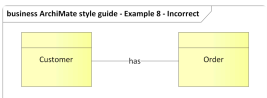
				• Sizing the element to span the width or height of multiple other elements makes the view clearer.
elm-003	Elements at the same level on a view SHOULD align horizontally & vertically and be spaced evenly.			• Offsetting an element's position makes the view clearer by enabling better connector routing.
elm-004	Elements MUST be resized if required to align to the grid on all four sides.			N/A
elm-005	Spacing between elements SHOULD be consistent, for example by using a 2 or 4 cell grid.			• Offsetting an element's position makes the view clearer by enabling better connector routing.
elm-006	Spacing between all nested elements and their encompassing element MUST be consistent, for example by using a 2 or 4 cell grid.			N/A
elm-007	Elements representing data entities MUST be named in the singular.			N/A

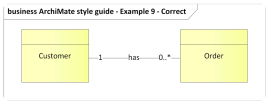
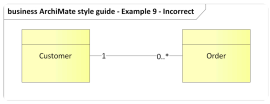
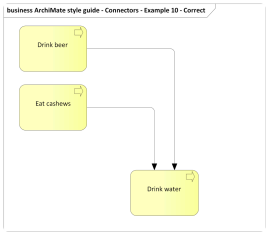
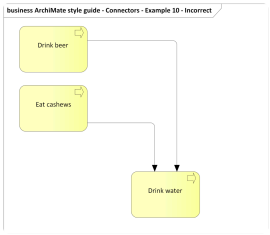
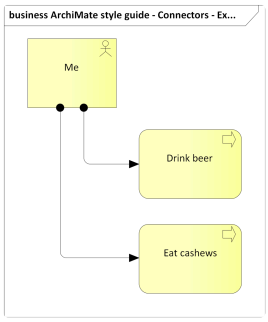
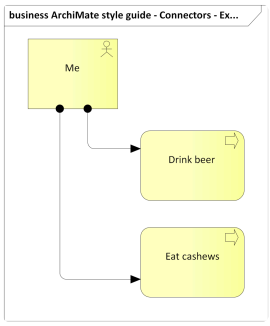
elm-008	Labels on elements that do not encapsulate child elements MUST be centred vertically and horizontally.			N/A
elm-009	Labels on elements that do encapsulate child elements SHOULD be positioned at the top and centred horizontally, ensuring they do not obstruct any lines. The placing (including if following one of the defined caveats) MUST be consistent across multiple encapsulating elements.			• If connectors from child elements to elements outside of the encapsulating element cross over the label, then the label SHOULD be positioned either: ◦ at the bottom and centred horizontally. ◦ at the left side, rotated anti-clockwise and centred vertically. ◦ at the right side, rotated anti-clockwise and centred vertically.

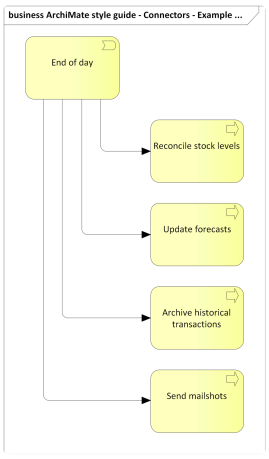
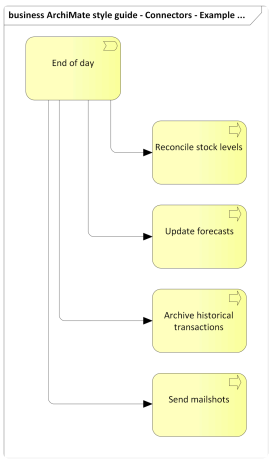
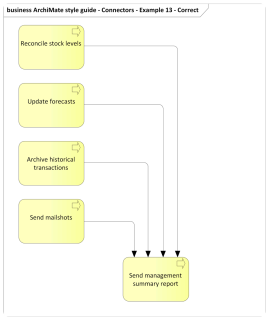
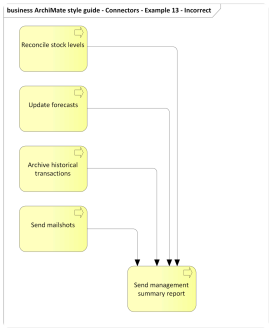
Connectors

Rule	Description	Example (correct)	Example (incorrect)	Caveats

cnn-001	Connectors MUST always be either a single horizontal line, single vertical line or be right-angled with rounded bends. Connectors MUST NOT run diagonally.			N/A
cnn-002	Connectors SHOULD not cross over each other.			• It is impossible to avoid crossing one connector over another. • Avoiding crossing one connector over another adds unnecessary complexity to the view resulting in it being less readable.
cnn-003	Connectors MUST have the minimum number of bends in them.			N/A
cnn-004	Connectors MUST run parallel to element edges and equidistant from elements that sandwich the relationship.			N/A

cnn-005	Labels SHOULD be placed on the horizontal part of a connector and MUST be centred horizontally & vertically.			• A connector only runs vertically. • The horizontal part of a connector is not large enough for the label. • The label is so long that it interferes with another element when centred. Consider a smaller label, or left / right shifting the text.
cnn-006	Labels on connectors MUST be rotated 90 degrees anti-clockwise if placed vertically and MUST be centred horizontally & vertically.			N/A
cnn-007	Labels on connectors SHOULD NOT be on the corner if the relationship has a bend.			• Both horizontal and vertical parts of the connector are too short for the label to avoid the corner.
cnn-008	*Association* connectors in data architecture views SHOULD indicate the multiplicity of the relationship between the			• The Directed property is set to *true* instead, indicating the

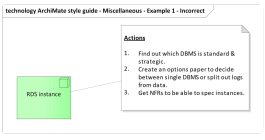
	source and target elements. Labels MUST be positioned close to their corresponding entity, with a small gap between the label and the entity itself.			‘many’ side of a 1:M relationship.
cnn-009	Labels for *Association* connectors in data architecture views MUST meaningfully describe the relationship between entities that are being modelled.			N/A
cnn-010	Where only a single connector originates from a side of an element it MUST attach to the centre of the source element.			N/A
cnn-011	Where only a single connector attaches to a side of an element it MUST attach to the centre of the target element.			N/A

cnn-012	Multiple connectors originating from the same side of a single element MUST be evenly spaced.			N/A
cnn-013	Multiple connectors attaching to the same side of an element MUST be evenly spaced.			N/A

Views

Rule	Description	Example (correct)	Example (incorrect)	Caveats
vws-001	Views MUST be named accordingly to indicate if the type of diagram is contextual, conceptual, logical or physical.			N/A

Miscellaneous

Rule	Description	Example (correct)	Example (incorrect)	Caveats
msc-001	The size of note elements used to list actions SHOULD be adjusted so that actions			• An action item is very long making it more readable

	do not wrap onto a new line.			to wrap to more than one line. • There is not enough space on the view to resize the note element sufficiently without moving or covering other elements.
msc-002	The Grouping element SHOULD be used to reduce visual clutter when multiple elements have the same relationship to one or more other elements.			
msc-003	Grouped concepts MUST be nested inside the Grouping element; explicit aggregation relationships from grouped concepts to the Grouping element MUST NOT be used.			
msc-004	The Grouping element MUST NOT be used when there is a more appropriate element available.	